Funny Weird or Funny Ha Ha?

By Neil Smith

PEG: **(Pg 125-150)** I loved Lucy, that loopy redhead with the Silly Putty face. When I was a girl, I'd watch the reruns of her show and howl. I'd practice my Lucy faces. Her bug-eyed surprise. Her clownish smile. Also her blubbering *Wahhhhhh!* when she was scolded by long-suffering Ricky Ricardo. In my favorite episode, Lucy auditioned for a TV commercial plugging a vitamin tonic.

LUCY: *(imitation)* Are you rundown and listless? Are you unpopular? The answer to all your problems, friends, is in this little bottle: Vitameatavegamin.

PEG: She poured a spoonful of the tonic and swallowed, her face twisting from its terrible taste. Vitameatavegamin contained 23 percent alcohol, and so, after several run-throughs of the commercial, Lucy was sloshed. She tripped over the product's name, flubbed her lines. Too tipsy to pour the tonic onto her spoon, she downed it straight from the bottle like a Bowery bum. The studio audience and I howled.

Later I put on that sketch for my parents and little sister, Elaine. I stood behind a card table, holding an old bottle of cough syrup filled with apple juice. Behind me was a poster with the slogan: DRINK YOUR WAY TO HEALTH! I had the red hair. I had the rubber face. My middle name was even Lucille. I was sure I'd grow up to be a comedienne.

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INTRODUCTION

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PEG: *(fondly remembering)* My late husband, Carl shared my weird sense of humor. For instance, when our son, Max (Max-a-Million, 19 years old now. He starts university in the fall). When Max was born, Carl hung an Edward Gorey poster beside Max's crib -- comical pen drawings of twenty-six little kids representing the letters of the alphabet. Each kid was killed in a bizarre way. "K is for Kate who was struck with an axe. L is for Leo who swallowed some tacks." *(beat)*

Carl died in an unusual way: he was lining up a shot during a curling championship when a blood vessel burst. After his death, "C is for Carl who died on the curling rink" kept running through my head. In the end, I had his ashes

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placed in a hollowed-out curling stone. *(holding up the curling stone by its curved handle, to Carl)* Welcome home, Carl.

I talk to Carl all the time, both out loud and in my head. Some people may think chatting with your dead husband is maudlin or the premise of a hokey Hollywood movie. But I'll do what I want. *(to Carl)* I miss you. *(to audience)* I feel a familiar, clinging loneliness. I close my eyes and . . .

*****Flashback******

PEG: *(to audience)* 20 of us at AA gathered in the basement of the Atwater Library. I stand at the front like a stand-up comic. The story I tell happened years ago. At the time, my sister owned a townhouse in the red-light district near the bus terminal. Elaine was away for the summer, and after work I'd go water the flowers in her backyard. I'd buy a bottle of wine and gulp most of it down. I'd lie sozzled in her backyard till the fog began dissipating. Then I'd ride the metro home.

One night I passed out in the backyard and my husband, sick with worry, found me there around midnight. By this time, I'd sobered up, although my brain felt like a bongo drum. "You're overreacting," I told him, even though Carl wasn't reacting at all. He was dead silent.

As we left my sister's house, we saw a woman teetering on high heels on the front sidewalk. Other than her heels and a tiny purse slung over one shoulder, she was naked -- high on something, a dopey grin on her face. I went inside to call 911. Soon a cop car pulled up, and we watched awkwardly as the two officers wrestled the naked lady into the back seat. By this time, she was laughing.

On our drive home, I tried telling my husband what the 911 operator had asked when I phoned.

OPERATOR: Could you describe the individual, ma' am?

PEG: Describe her? She's the only naked broad on the street. But if you have trouble picking her out, she's the one with the red purse.

(to audience) The people at AA laugh. I tell them that Carl wouldn't even look at me. He glared straight ahead. Finally, he muttered, "A cautionary tale, Peg. A cautionary tale." But it wasn't. Not for me. That naked lady wasn't a warning; she confirmed what I thought an addict was. Someone lurching out of control, demeaning herself in

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public. ***I*** wasn't that. ***I*** was a respected MD. I never missed a day of work even during my worst hangovers.

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PEG: *(to audience)* A week after my move, my bare feet rest on the curling stone as I read a book: an inside look at the *I Love Lucy* show. In real life, Ricky was a womanizer and a cheat and Fred a mean-spirited drunk. Ethel struggled with soul-crushing despair and suicidal thoughts. Even Lucy said she could ***play*** funny but she was not naturally funny. I've accomplished little. Maybe I have too much crap around me to find my core. I get an idea. I drag myself up, find a roll of paper towels and rip off three sheets. I write IN, OUT and MAX on the sheets before taping them to the walls. For the next few days, I sort through my boxes, Carl egging me on.

CARL'S VOICE: *With your red hair, that green sweater makes you look like a leprechaun.*

PEG: Out goes the sweater. Out go my old watercolor set, three wristwatches, a desk fan, and on and on. Once my out pile has grown large enough, I load the junk into moving boxes, which I heave into the Dumpster behind my building. Max's stuff goes into boxes that I drag to the storage locker in the basement. Within days, I've discarded two-thirds of my belongings. What the hell am I doing?

CARL'S VOICE: *You 're reinventing yourself again. Wife, mother, doctor, drunk, twelve-stepper, widow. Who will Peg be next? What do* we *get rid of now?*

PEG: I eye the curling stone. I stroke its surface. The granite is called Blue Hone, quarried in Scotland. When Carl died, Max was upset that I'd stopped up his father's ashes in a curling stone. Why not sprinkle them in a forest or a river the way normal people do? But I insisted on the curling stone. I wanted Carl around . . . for the camaraderie.

CARL'S VOICE: *But that's not all, is it? There's more to it than that.*

PEG: *(wiping away tears, softly)* The memory of love.

CARL'S VOICE: *You've stayed dry this long because of one thing. Me. My constant watch. I'm your rock.*

PEG: My hand grabs the stone's handle. I grip till my knuckles turn white. I sit awhile and then finally open the bottle of Chardonnay. I slide the cork out. It makes a sound like a kiss. I pour, twisting the bottle slightly so no wine spills. *(takes a drink)* Warm pear. Golden apple.

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Vanilla. *(to Carl)* I proved you wrong, buster! *(to audience)* I drink two big glasses.

CARL'S VOICE: *The comedy festival is still on. Why don't we go? For old times sake.*

PEG: *(to audience)* So I grab a cab to the Just for Laughs festival. Saint-Denis Street is closed off. On a platform, a woman dressed as the Tin Man, with a funnel on her head and her face painted silver, stands motionless as if rusted solid. Also on hand are acrobats, jugglers of china cups and the dreaded mime. The marquee advertises Andrea Martin's one-woman show, *The Lint Inside My Belly Button.*

*****Flashback*****

PEG: *(to audience)* One of the last drinks I had was at my sister's fortieth. Everyone got more liquored up than usual. Especially me. Whenever the Chardonnay dipped below three-quarters empty, I motioned to the waiter. At the end of the brunch, I hugged Elaine too hard, and Carl and I left the restaurant. It was a sunny fall afternoon, and I insisted on a stroll, although by this time I was staggering. At the top of a steep cobblestone street, we came upon a blond man pushing an old lady in a wheelchair, a plaid blanket over her legs. The woman, who wore sunglasses and a rain bonnet, was so stooped, I figured she was snoozing.

MAN: Could you folks direct us to Chinatown?

PEG: *(slurring)* Oh, I love Chinatown! *(to audience)* Carl gave directions while I stood there pretending to be sober. As the young man pointed toward Chinatown, his hand let go of the wheelchair, which slid forward and began zipping down the street.

I ran after the lady. Halfway down the street, my heart hammering, I grabbed the back of the wheelchair, but then my ankle twisted and I fell to the ground. The wheelchair overturned and the sleeping lady pitched out and tumbled lifeless over the cobblestones. Carl came running toward me. "The lady, the lady," I shouted. "Help the lady!" She was lying still. Carl turned her over. Somehow her sunglasses and rain bonnet had stayed attached to her head. "What the hell?" Carl said. He picked the old lady up by the shoulders of her cardigan and shook her. Her head lolled. Her orthopedic shoes swung. "She's a dummy!" he yelled.

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Out of nowhere came the fellow with a handheld camera. He explained we were the victims of a setup for the comedy festival, a candid-camera show called *Funny Weird or Funny Ha Ha?* He had a waiver for us to sign. I sat on the cobblestones, one knee scraped and bloody, my ankle throbbing, my husband kneeling beside me. I was about to laugh till I turned to Carl. A vein in his neck looked as swollen as a garden hose. He stood, wrested the camera from the guy and heaved it down the street.

CARL: *(yelling)* You hurt my wife!

MAN: Maybe she fell because she's had too much to drink.

PEG: *(to audience)* Carl flew at him. I watched my sweet, docile husband, his fist full of blond hair, smash a man's face against cobblestones. *(beat)* The blond man, eventually let the charges drop.

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PEG: *(to audience)* It's the last day of my vacation, and I'm dressing up. I curled my hair and piled it atop my head. I'm wearing red lipstick and contact lenses that turn my eyes baby blue. I'm Lucille Ball.

CARL'S VOICE: *You zany redhead.*

PEG: *(to audience)* I'm heading off to AA. In the basement

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of the Atwater Library, I'm standing in the women's washroom with Ricky Ricardo. His hair is greased back into a pompadour. He has on a jacket with a handkerchief peeking out of his pocket.

TONY: *(in a fake Latino accent)* I'm nervous, Lucy. I don't have no acting 'sperience."

PEG: *(to Tony)* We alcoholics ***all*** have years of acting experience. *(to audience)* The story we're sharing tonight is that of Ricky and Lucy, sketches I've written and persuaded Tony to co-star in. Lucy hiding her Vitameatavegamin bottles in the clothes hamper. Ricky blowing a gasket. Lucy making her own wine by stomping barefoot in a vat of grapes. Ricky yelling in rapid-fire Spanish and calling Lucy a wino. Lucy wailing *Wahhhhhh! (rolling her eyes, in her best Lucy imitation)* Drink your way to health!

(to audience) Whenever these people stand up and share their stories, a hush falls over the room, a stillness that feels sacred. I love that stillness. It keeps me coming back here. But tonight it's not what I want. Tonight I want this room ringing with laughter.

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